3

Youth, Education and Citizenship

Introduction

I was born in my beloved homeland Pakistan wherein Islamic traditions hold forth. We can live our lives according to our religion here, it is our home and our religion is Islam. To me Pakistan means that there is 'No God but Allah'.

(Student, Female, Sahiwal)

Education should use national interest, historical heritage, religion or multi-culturalism as tools to engender a sense of belonging with the country. Historically our educational system has selectively or collectively used the above mentioned factors to create national cohesion.

(Student, Male, Karachi)

The education system is instrumental in pushing the national narrative of the security state, as the ideological struggle over citizenship in Pakistan continues into the twenty-first century. What is the meaning of Pakistan? Was it established in the name of Islam to be an Islamic state following Sharia law, or a homeland for Muslims and religious minorities under secular rule? These questions continue to be debated by media analysts, scholars and political actors (Yasmeen 2013; Zaidi 2011; Nelson 2008; Rais 2007; Dean 2005; Ahmed 2002; Whaites 1998), yet the definition of citizenship moves beyond a simplistic dichotomous framework as both religious and secular political actors have used Islam to promote and legitimize their political objectives. It is this (ab)use of religion for political gain that has cemented the place of Islam within the Pakistani citizenship discourse.

Islam gained a legitimate place in the national narrative of an independent Pakistan as early as the Objectives Resolution of 1949, only to take on a state of permanence under the Constitution of Pakistan 1956, which declared Pakistan an Islamic Republic. Islam was meant to weave together an ethnically